Consortium of Gujarati Schools (CGS)

Biennial General Meeting

Report for 2024 – 2026

The last BGM of the organisation was held on 19th May 2024, when a new committee was elected for 2024-26. The elected members were as follows.

Chair: Jayantbhai Tanna; **Vice Chairs**: Shobhaben Joshi (Midlands) and Chetanaben Bhatt-Shah (Northwest); **Secretary**: Vijyaben Bhanderi; **Treasurer**: Rekhaben Patel (Kenton); **Past Chair**: Sonalben Shah.

Committee Members: Dipaben Chhatralia; Hasvinaben Shah; Rekhaben Patel (Kingston); Jatinbhai Shah; Prafullaben Shah; Ritaben Kamdar; Ritaben Patel; Tusharbhai Shah and Veljibhai Vekaria

1) CGS Committee and membership

In order to make CGS more involved nationally, we decided to have two Vice Chairs, representing members from the Midlands and the Northwest in particular. This has worked exceedingly well as we have held parallel training sessions in London and Leicester for our teachers. Many teachers from the Bolton in the Northwest joined our courses in Leicester. There is therefore a shared sense of participation and support for Gujarati teaching and learning.

Our Rules allow us two kinds of membership. All the organisations running Gujarati schools become **Organisation Members** @£25 per school. Three main officers from each organisation would become CGS members advising the committee on the training needs and support. All teachers and others may become **Individual members** @£10 per teacher. They would also be voting members of CGS and would be entitled to participate in training organised by CGS. Both these memberships run for two years. The current period is 2024-2026.

Since the last BGM, we have 89 Individual Members and 14 Organisation Members. The Organisation members running Gujarati schools in the evenings and/or weekends are:

BAPS Neasden; Shishukunj Harrow; Shishukunj Mill Hill; Mandhata Y&C; Alperton High School; Oshwal North; Oshwal Northwest; Oshwal South; Veda Mandir Bolton; Pandav Vidya Shala; SKSS Temple Willesden; SKSS Temple East London; SKLPC Saturday School and Milton Keynes Hindu Association.

We hope that Gujarati schools from Leicester and other areas will also become our Organisation Members soon.

2) CGS Membership and School Information Forms

We sent out 'School Information Forms' to all schools and received returns from only a couple. We would like the completed forms returned from all schools, including those in the Midlands and Northwest in order to get a clear picture of the current number of schools and students learning Gujarati in the UK, and number of entries for GCSE and A Level examinations.

Both Organisation/Individual Membership and School Information Forms for 2026-28 will be sent out again in September 2026. We hope organisations realise the importance of this information.

3) Committee and course planning Meetings

Since the BGM on 19th May 2024, we have had twelve (14) Executive Committee meetings. All meetings were held on Zoom. Most of the meetings were well attended by committee members regularly and punctually, however we had had some notable exceptions who attended only one or two meeting.

Notes of the meetings were taken in detail and agreed at all meetings. All documents were emailed to committee members in advance. Matters were discussed and debated and decisions made through active participation by all present.

4) Course for Gujarati teachers held on 21st July 2024 in Wembley

A training course for Gujarati teachers focusing on **Planning, Assessing and Speaking** was held on **21st July 2024 at Sanatan Hindu Mandir, Wembley.**

Thirty-One (31) teachers from a range of Gujarati schools attended the course. The course was led by Jayantbhai Tanna with contributions from Vijyaben Bhanderi, Rekhaben Patel and Ritaben Kamdar.

The course focused on what makes a lesson effective, how teachers would be able to know what, and how much the pupils had learned in the lesson. The second part focused on improving teachers' skills in assessing the quality of students' Gujarati Speaking skills.

The feedback from the teachers was very positive as outlined below.

Training Quality	Strongly agree	Agree	Neutral	Disagree	Strongly disagree
The overall quality of the training was high	13	12	0	0	0
This training will benefit me in my teaching	9	16	0	0	0

What was good?

The teachers described the easy-to-follow booklet as excellent. They found the content and suggested ideas were superb. The ideas about sharing objectives, a 3-part lesson, learning styles and PALM+A in-Picture tasks were what many teachers would implement in their own lessons.

It was very well organised with brilliant videos and recordings of Gujarati conversation ideas and suggestions to improve pupils' confidence and spontaneity in Speaking. Tests. Videos of classroom teaching were very useful. The venue was easily accessible and calm. The food was very tasty with many varieties!

What was not so good?

There were no primary school videos (because the VHS tapes could not be accessed). There were no videos of Gujarati lessons (as these were not available nor made in the UK). It would be easier to hear if a sound system were used. The parking for the day was too expensive!

Suggestions for courses in the future

More focus needed on how to tutor younger students, especially grammar. Need a session on improving Reading and Writing skills; More support on teaching the Environment theme at GCSE; Arrange visiting lessons of more skilled teachers; Exchange of ideas on use of resources, Sharing good practice; Feedback and news from GCSE exam board; ideas on course/Workshop for parents.

5) Training course for Gujarati teachers held on 8th September 2024 at Leicester

A training course for Gujarati teachers focusing on **Planning, Assessing and Speaking** was held on 8th September 2024 **at Jalaram Community Centre, Leicester**.

Twenty-Nine (29) teachers from a range of Gujarati schools in Leicester and Bolton attended the course. The course was led by Jayantbhai Tanna with contributions from Rekhaben Patel and Ritaben Kamdar.

The course focused on what makes a lesson effective, and how teachers would be able to know what and how much the pupils had learned in the lesson. The second part focused on improving teachers' skills in assessing the quality of students' Gujarati Speaking skills.

The feedback from the teachers was very positive as outlined below.

Training Quality	Strongly agree	Agree	Neutral	Disagree	Strongly Disagree
The quality of training was high	12	9	0	0	0
The training will help my teaching	14	7	0	0	0

What was good?

Planning and Assessment power points and videos very good; How to plan a lesson to make it interesting; Presentations and explanations were easily understood; Discussion on learning styles; Involving whole class; Big Books reading; Use of White boards for spellings and reading; Techniques of getting children involved; Speaking presentation by Rekhaben and Ritaben were very good; GCSE Speaking session very useful; Candidate conversation recording and follow up discussion very useful; Expanded our knowledge and skills, teaching techniques;

Training was very good, running according to the programme, no time wasted; Very good information was shared; Good opportunities to share views of other teachers; Picked up many points useful for our school from the course; Booklet was very good; food was delicious!

What was not so good?

Most of the discussion and presentation was in English; could have shown more resources, books to use; Hissing noise from microphone made hearing speakers difficult at times.

Suggestions for courses in the future

How to make Gujarati community aware of the trend of our language going down; How to use online resources, Smart Board; Gujarati videos storytelling, singing, teaching vowels etc; Gujarati teaching videos; Display teaching materials and resources; Improving pupils' discipline.

6) A Level Gujarati Zoom support sessions – 1½ hours – October 2024 to 4th April 2025

We organised twelve A Level Gujarati support sessions on Zoom for Gujarati teachers to help them improve their understanding of the course demands and run A Level Gujarati classes in the future. The aims of the course were to:

- gain knowledge and understanding of Gujarati at a higher level.
- offer deeper and varied learning opportunities to their students.
- inspire Gujarati students to opt for 'A' Level Gujarati in the future.
- gain opportunities for employment in areas that need your skills in translating and interpreting from or into Gujarati.

The course was led and delivered by our Vice Chair and renowned Gujarati devotee, Mrs Shobhaben Joshi from Leicester. Twelve teachers from different areas enrolled on the course. They found the course interesting are enjoyable. The sessions were eye-openers for them. They found the texts and films interesting and enjoyable. The research element and the synoptic task challenged their understanding and application skills. Six of the twelve took the A Level Gujarati examinations in June 2025. All six obtained A* grades! We congratulated and honoured them all on their fantastic achievement and presented special trophies to them.

We hope these teachers will now be able to use their knowledge and expertise to motivate their students and other teachers to prepare for A Level Gujarati in the future. I would like to thank and commend Shobhaben for delivering the course voluntarily with such passion, commitment and skill. I would also like to thank Chandrakantbhai Mehta (Brighton), Dr. Amritbhai Shah, Vandanaben Joshi and Rameshbhai Odedra – all from NCGO - for their generous donations towards the candidates' examination entry fees.

We planned a repeat of the A Level Gujarati Zoom course in October 2025. Unfortunately, on this occasion, we had to cancel as we received only One application!

7) 'Improving Gujarati Writing' course held in Leicester on 21st September 2025

A training course for Gujarati teachers focusing on Improving Writing skills in Gujarati was held on 21st September 2025 at Fullhurst Community College, Leicester. Eighteen (18) teachers from a range of Gujarati schools in Leicester attended the course. The course was led by Jayantbhai Tanna with contributions from Rekhaben Patel, Shobhaben Joshi and Chetanaben Bhatt-Shah.

The course focused on using assessment criteria to improve the teaching of Writing in Gujarati for pupils of primary and GCSE classes. The first session focussed on using assessment levels in Writing for younger pupils. The second session dealt with using prescribed GCSE assessment criteria to understand how standards in Gujarati Writing for pupils might be raised.

The afternoon session gave teachers an opportunity to assess pupils' specimen Writing scripts using and applying the assessment levels for primary and GCSE criteria for older pupils. All teachers found the day to be extremely beneficial as can be seen in the completed feedback forms summarised below.

The feedback from the teachers was very positive as outlined below.

One-day Writing course for Teachers - Leicester - 21st September 2025						
Training Quality	**Strongly agree**	**Agree**	**Neutral**	**Disagree**	**Strongly disagree**	**Total**
The overall quality of training was high	15	2	0	0	0	17
The training will benefit my teaching	16	1	0	0	0	17

What was good?

Refreshed marking criteria from a different angle; extremely informative sessions; presented very well; it was excellent, amazing; levels and structure of assessment explained well; group work, discussion, opinions were very good; presenters were passionate; all very useful; relevant; opportunity for discussion with others on different topics; met colleagues from different schools; assessment levels explained very well; teaching gender linked with words useful tip; idea of all working together as a team in your school good; opportunity for marking primary and GCSE scripts was good; learning about assessment criteria very helpful; marking pupils' sample scripts was very helpful.

What was not so good?

Joint assessment idea was very good, many thanks but time not always available in school; more resources should be made available online for all teachers to check assessment levels of pupils in Reading, Writing, Speaking and Listening.

Main action points for my teaching

Teach using the GCSE marking scheme as a guide; Apply assessment criteria in my teaching (4); will use level descriptors; will use and share tips, ideas from other teachers; will use self-assessment ideas; insist on correct and clear sounds for Gujarati letters and vowels while speaking; positive teaching; use of paragraphs in writing; encourage pupils to extend their writing; will support more schools joining in courses, meetings to get more ideas, materials and donations.

'Improving Gujarati Writing' course was planned for teachers in the London area on 14th September 2025 but was undersubscribed and rescheduled for 16th November 2025. Once again, the course received a very disappointing response and had to be cancelled.

8) Examination Centre difficulties

Over the years, many parents of Gujarati students have experienced many problems in getting schools to enter their children entered for GCSE and A Level Gujarati examinations. Most mainstream schools are unwilling to take on the extra administrative responsibility of administering GCSE and A Level examinations. They also have to find decent quality Gujarati teacher examiners for the GCSE Speaking examinations. It would also be true to say that apart from BAPS Neasden, most of our own community examination centres are also not very helpful in this area.

In order to try and get one of our own centres, CGS and Sangat Advisory Centre applied for validation to Pearson Edexcel Examination Board but were refused, as Sangat did not have a safe and secure room that could be a permanent examination office throughout the year! We will now be approaching local authorities and request them for suitable Council accommodation that could be converted to an exam office.

9) Financial report

This year, we are in a balanced financial position as we have managed to run four courses and recruited a suitable number of Individual Members. We have also managed to get some donations.

Our income from courses, donations and membership has enabled us to pay for our expenses like venue and lunch costs for our courses. The current balance at the bank is **£3899.50**. More details are given in the Finance Report by our Treasurer Rekhaben Patel.

10) Linking with Rushey Mead Academy, Leicester

Rushey Mead Academy is an 11-16 school in Leicester that provides lessons in Gujarati at KS3 and KS4. We have recently arranged to meet with the school in June 2026 to develop strategies to improve further, the teaching and learning of Gujarati in the school and the local community.

11) Appreciation

I would like to take this opportunity of thanking all my committee members who have worked so hard to arrange courses and meetings. Shobhaben Joshi as Vice Chair and course leader, Vijyaben Bhanderi as Secretary and Rekhaben Patel (Kenton) as Treasurer have always been at my disposal, helping me in running the organisation efficiently and smoothly. Chetanaben Bhatt-Shah, Rekhaben Patel (Kingston) and Ritaben Kamdar have spent hours preparing for our courses. Tusharbhai Shah has given me invaluable suggestions, ideas and proposals which I valued highly. I am truly grateful for all their contributions, dedication, commitment and for their passion for Gujarati.

Members of the committee have taken on organisational tasks for training sessions willingly and with dedication. In addition, of course, I thank all the teachers and Head Teachers who attended our courses. And I thank all the donors who have given us such wonderful support.

Finally, I say a big ‘Thank You’ to you all!

Jayant Tanna

Chair, Consortium of Gujarati Schools

2024-26